

Workshop:

Securing your PC

Whether you've assembled a new PC, bought one right off the assembly line or if the growing concern of security has finally dawned on you after countless crashes and system formats – you have now decided that your PC deserves a higher level of protection. How do you go about executing this mountain of a task, considering all the armies of viruses, trojans, worms, spyware and other monstrosities of the digital world just waiting to claw their way into your beloved computer as soon as you connect it to an internet line? This is quite true. In fact, some estimates say that it can take only about 20 minutes for an unpatched and unprotected computer to be attacked once connected to the internet.

Read on and find out the various steps you can take to help save your precious PC. While some of the steps are of a fire fighting nature, you'll find that most of them are preventive. Many are just safe computing practices that you need to follow to the tooth to avoid infection at all costs. When you get an infection, chances are that your installed security will be rendered useless so the key lies in not letting an infection occur in the first place. After all, as they say, prevention is better than cure. So let us begin. The first and foremost step is to install an antivirus.

Install antivirus

An antivirus is the first layer of protection that you can install on your PC. There are literally hundreds of antivirus solutions available out there. Some of the biggest names are obviously paid solutions such as Norton, Symantec, Kaspersky and McAfee. However, in the free realm there are solutions available too. Free solutions include packages such as Avira AntiVir Personal, AVG and Avast. When choosing antivirus software, you need to ask yourself these questions:



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• Does the antivirus solution have internet updates?

Most antivirus solutions worth their while have a virus definition database that is constantly updated. The antivirus software then connects to this database and downloads the latest virus definitions and signatures. This way, it is prepped and ready with information on how to fight the newest baddies of the virus world.

• Is it easy on system resources?

Antivirus software has to be in an 'always on' state to provide you with constant and continuous protection. Any AV application adds itself to the list of processes that are constantly running in the background.

This consumes resources reducing the overall system resources available to you to run other applications. You wouldn't want an antivirus that slows down your PC to a snails pace. Some applications such as the Norton AV, although popular and effective, are notorious for being heavy on the system.

• Is the detection rate satisfactory?

An antivirus is after all only as good as the number of viruses it is able to detect. There are independent third party organisations that test the detection rate of AV products. According to leading authorities on the subject, your antivirus must have a detection rate that

is as high as possible. In fact, in a report by AV-Comparatives, Avira Premium has the highest overall detection rate of 99.6 per cent. Since no AV offers total (100 per cent) protection, this brings the question of whether one should bother having an AV at all? The answer is quite simple – Yes! The premise is to do your best. Implement other security procedures and tools that will help in cases where malware makes it past your anti-virus defences. We'll talk about these fire fighting measures later on in the workshop.

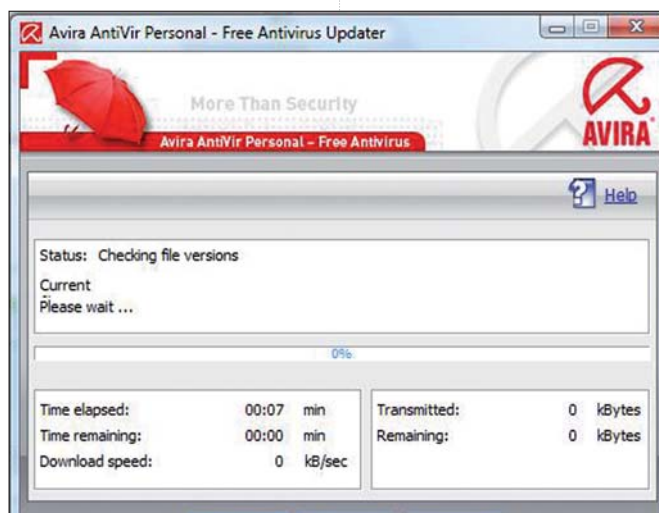
Most antivirus solutions are single-click applications that are self configured in the best possible way. This means they are easy to use for average users. What you should know is that if you use multiple AV solutions it may not offer you the proportionate increase in protection. In fact, it is likely to cause conflicts. Also, remember to keep your virus database up-to-date.

Some antivirus providers, even the free ones will often include another class of security application such as anti-spyware, or rootkit checker. These may also prove to be advantageous, but remember to disable them if you are using standalone solutions for each of those purposes.

Install firewall

A software firewall is like a filter that allows certain packets of information to pass based on some rules and parameters. It disallows applications to freely communicate over a network. Therefore, most firewalls will raise a pop-up dialog whenever an application tries to communicate over the internet. When such a case happens the firewall asks the user to allow or deny the application communication rights. If the user allows then the application is placed under the exceptions list of the firewall. These exception programs are allowed to communicate outward, but if a worm or malicious program tries to send information outwards it will be blocked.

Windows too has a built in firewall but one can install a



Avira Updater